

Rerouted Barrels: Tanker Traffic Through Hormuz, Bab el-Mandeb and Suez, 2023–2026

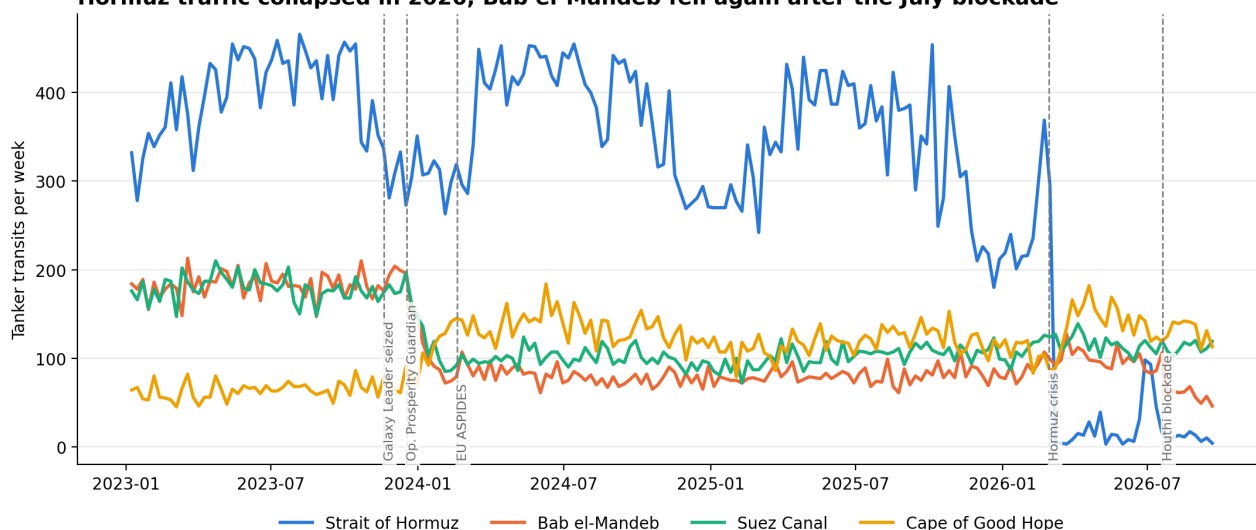
Saudi crude moved to the Red Sea after Hormuz closed; since the 20 July Houthi blockade, tanker capacity through Bab el-Mandeb has fallen to 71% below its 2023 level.

Maria Cekmariova · Data: IMF PortWatch, 1 Jan 2023 – 20 Sep 2026 · Code: github.com/marijacek/rerouted-barrels

KEY FINDINGS

1. **Hormuz:** recorded tanker capacity was 77% below its 2023 baseline in H1 2026 and 99% below after 20 July. Daily tanker transits fell from 36 on 28 February to 5 on 1 March. A brief reopening after the 17 June US–Iran MoU lifted traffic to about 95 tankers a week (vs about 400 in 2023) before attacks on 6–7 July.
2. **Bab el-Mandeb:** tanker capacity partially recovered, from –56% in 2024 to –46% in H1 2026, then fell to –71% after the 20 July Houthi blockade. Tankers had returned faster than containerships (–47% vs –70% by count in H1 2026).
3. **Suez and the Cape:** Suez tanker capacity barely moved after the blockade (–44% to –47%), while the Cape of Good Hope ran 51% above baseline, with tanker transits roughly doubled (+106%).

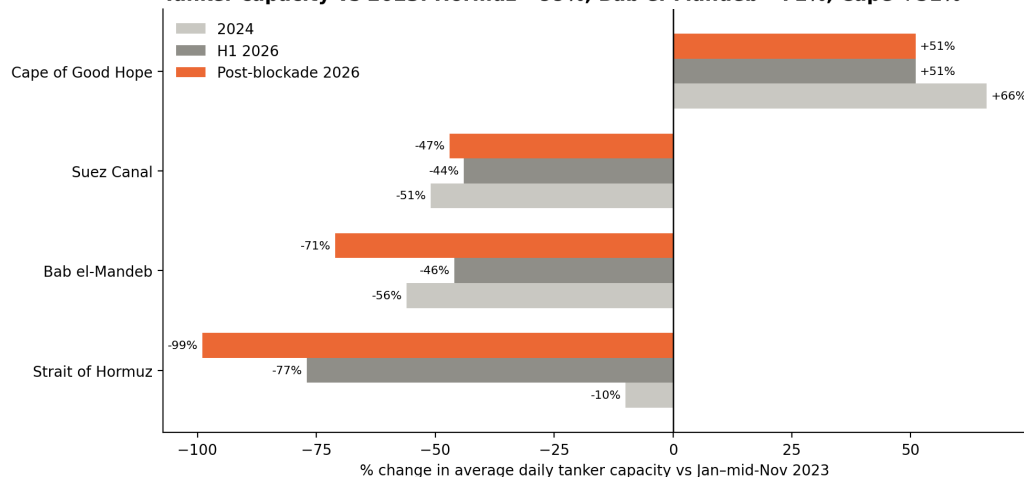
Hormuz traffic collapsed in 2026; Bab el-Mandeb fell again after the July blockade



CONTEXT

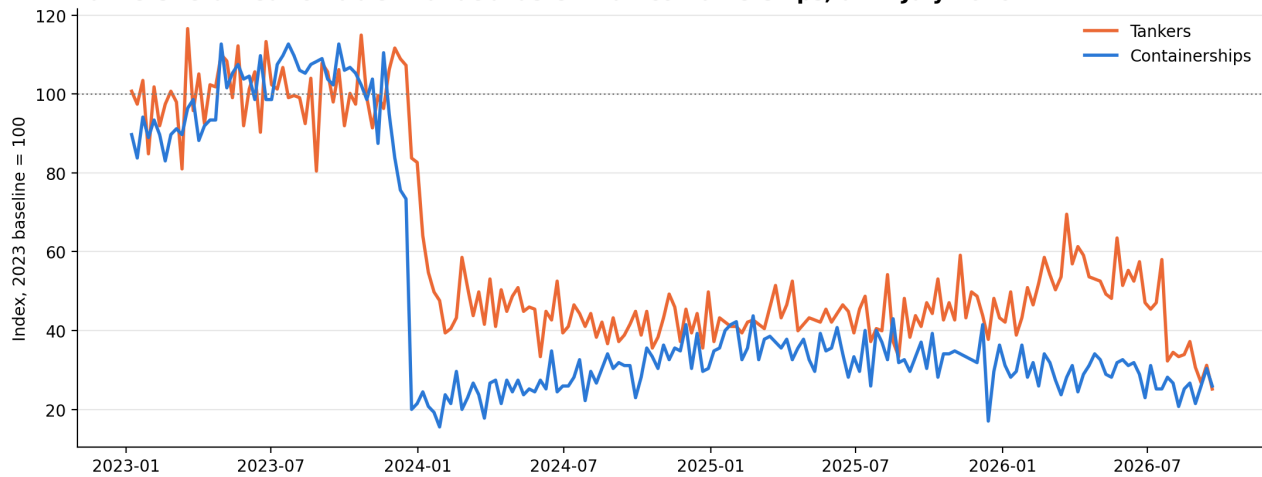
Three shocks have hit the Gulf–Europe/Asia oil route: Houthi attacks on shipping from November 2023; the war that began on 28 February 2026, after which tanker traffic through the Strait of Hormuz halted from 1 March and Saudi Arabia pushed crude west to Yanbu on the Red Sea; and the Houthi naval blockade of Saudi shipping announced on 20 July 2026. Around 6 mb/d of oil moves through Bab el-Mandeb toward Asia, including about 1.9 mb/d of Russian crude.

Tanker capacity vs 2023: Hormuz –99%, Bab el-Mandeb –71%, Cape +51%



Note: H1 2026 includes January–February, before the war began on 28 February. Post-blockade = 20 July–20 September 2026 (63 days).

Tankers returned to Bab el-Mandeb faster than containerships, until July 2026



MARKET IMPLICATIONS

- **Freight:** longer routes and split loadings tie up tanker capacity. Lloyd's List reports VLCCs loading partly at Yanbu and topping up at Sidi Kerir after moving north via Suez, contributing to a third spot-rate spike since the crisis began.
- **India:** the most exposed importer, with over half of its crude imports transiting Bab el-Mandeb while Gulf supply via Hormuz is also disrupted.
- **Russia:** about 1.9 mb/d of Russian crude to Asia uses the Red Sea route, so the blockade raises transit risk and cost for these flows even though Saudi shipping is the stated target.
- **What to watch:** weekly Bab el-Mandeb tanker transits against Suez (a further fall at Suez would signal that the northbound Yanbu route is also under pressure), and Hormuz transits after any renewed agreement.

METHOD AND LIMITATIONS

- Method: daily tanker transits and tanker capacity from IMF PortWatch; baseline = average day, 1 Jan–15 Nov 2023 (before the Galaxy Leader seizure); comparison windows: 2024, H1 2026 and 20 Jul–20 Sep 2026 (63 days).
- PortWatch counts rely on AIS signals; ships that switch transponders off in conflict zones are undercounted, so Hormuz figures are recorded transits.
- Transit counts and capacity are not barrels actually carried; the post-blockade window is short and figures may be revised.

SOURCES

IMF PortWatch. [Daily Chokepoint Transit Calls and Trade Volume Estimates](#). Dataset, accessed 24 September 2026.

S&P Global Energy (Platts). [Oil tanker traffic disrupted in Strait of Hormuz main shipping lanes: CAS](#). 1 March 2026.

Al Jazeera. [Strait of Hormuz: What has happened since the US-Iran MoU on June 17?](#) 9 July 2026.

Al Jazeera. [Can the Suez save Asian oil consumers after Houthis shut Bab al-Mandeb?](#) 22 July 2026.

Lloyd's List Intelligence. [Red Sea Brief: 3 September 2026](#). 3 September 2026.

Independent analysis based on public data; not investment advice.